

Enderton's Elements of Set Theory

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Chapter 1

Axioms and Operations

1.1 First Axioms

Extensionality axiom

If two sets have the exact same members, then they are equal:

$$\forall A \forall B [\forall x (x \in A \leftrightarrow x \in B) \rightarrow A = B]$$

(The nested implication is not an equivalence because the other direction is already true. Declaring it would be redundant.)

Empty set axiom

There is a set having no members:

$$\exists B \forall x (x \notin B)$$

Pairing axiom

For any sets u and v , there is a set having as members just u and v :

$$\forall u \forall v \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = u \text{ or } x = v)$$

Union axiom, Preliminary form

For any sets a and b , there is a set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both):

$$\forall a \forall b \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in a \text{ or } x \in b)$$

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Power set axiom

For any set a , there is a set whose members are exactly the subsets of a :

$$\forall a \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \subseteq a)$$

We can rewrite $x \subseteq a$ in terms of the definition of $\subseteq$:

$$\forall t (t \in x \rightarrow t \in a)$$

This list will be further expanded later to include

- Subset axioms
- Replacement axioms
- Infinity axiom
- Regularity axiom
- Choice axiom

The union axiom will be also be restated in a stronger form.

1.1.1 Definitions

Definition 1.1. $\emptyset$ is the set having no members.

This definition bestows the name “ $\emptyset$ ” on a certain set. When we write down such a definition we must be sure of two things: that there exists such a set and that there cannot be more than one set having no members. The empty set axiom provides the first fact and extensionality provides the second. Without both facts the symbol “ $\emptyset$ ” would not be well defined.

Definition 1.2.

- For any sets u and v , the **pair set** $\{u, v\}$ is the set whose members are u and v .
- For any sets a and b , the **union** $a \cup b$ is the set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both).
- For any set a , the **power set** $\mathcal{P}a$ is the set whose members are exactly the subsets of a .

The existence and uniqueness proofs guaranteeing all of these definitions can be proved using the empty set axiom, the pairing axiom, the union axiom, and the power set axiom respectively, each in combination with the extensionality axiom.

We can use the pairing and union together to form other finite sets. Given any x we can denote the pair set $\{x, x\}$ as the *singleton* $\{x\}$ (since the pair exists and is unique). For any given x_1, x_2, x_3 we can define

$$\{x_1, x_2, x_3\} = \{x_1, x_2\} \cup \{x_3\}$$

(since the union exists and is unique for any two particular sets). Similarly we can define $\{x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4\}$ and so forth.
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Notation

Our existence axioms have been of the form “there exists a set B whose members are those sets x satisfying the condition $--$ ”

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

Where if some other sets $t_1, \dots, t_k$ are involved in the condition, then the full version becomes

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

With the blank filled in by some expression involving $t_1, \dots, t_k$ and x . The empty set axiom can be written as

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \neq x)$$

Now let us be more general and consider any statement of the form

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

If the statement were true, then the set B , by the statement itself, as well as by equivalence, can be named by use of the abstraction notation:

$$B = \{x \mid --\}$$

*My interpretation was that showing the existence and uniqueness of B amounts to showing:

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k [\exists B (\forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)) \wedge \forall B' (\forall x (x \in B' \leftrightarrow --) \rightarrow B' = B)]$$

The sets defined earlier can similarly be named in this notation:

$$\begin{aligned}\emptyset &= \{x \mid x \neq x\} \\ \{u, v\} &= \{x \mid x = u \text{ or } x = v\} \\ a \cup b &= \{x \mid x \in a \text{ or } x \in b\} \\ \mathcal{P}a &= \{x \mid x \subseteq a\}\end{aligned}$$

Note that it is not the case that all statements of the general form are true. For instance

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = x)$$

is false as it asserts the existence of a set B to which every set belongs.

1.1.2 Subset axioms

Subset axioms

For each formula $--$ not containing B , the following is an axiom:

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \forall c \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in c \wedge --)$$

Given an existing set c , this axiom asserts the existence of a set whose members are exactly those sets in c such that $--$.

See that such a set must be the subset of an existing set c (thus the name). The set can be named by use of a variation on the abstraction notation:

$$B = \{x \in c \mid --\}$$

Intersection

One of the subset axioms is

$$\forall a \forall c \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in c \wedge x \in a)$$

The axiom asserts the existence of the set we define to be the *intersection* $c \cap a$ of c and a .

Relative complement

We also have as a subset axiom

$$\forall A \forall B \exists S \forall x (x \in S \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin B)$$

This set S is the *relative complement* of B in A , denoted $A - B$.

1.1.3 Russell's Paradox

Theorem 1.3. *There is no set to which every set belongs.*

Proof. Suppose, for contradiction, that there exists a set A to which every set belongs. By the subset axiom we can assert

$$\forall A \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin x)$$

That is, the existence of

$$B = \{x \in A \mid x \notin x\}$$

By construction of B we have

$$\forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin x)$$

and

$$B \in B \leftrightarrow B \in A \wedge B \notin B$$

We know that $B \in A$. This can be used to show

$$B \in B \leftrightarrow B \notin B \quad \square$$

The idea here is that if B were not a member of itself, then by definition B should be in B . But if B were a member of itself, then by definition it should not be a member of itself.

1.1.4 Improved Union Axiom

The previously described union operation allowed us to consider the union of two sets, and by repeating the operation, the union of three sets and so on. Suppose however we want the union of infinitely many sets:

$$A = \{b_0, b_1, b_2, \dots\}$$

For this we need a more general union operation:

$$\begin{aligned} \bigcup A &= \bigcup_i b_i \\ &= \{x \mid x \text{ belongs to some member } b_i \text{ of } A\} \end{aligned}$$

This leads us to define the union of any set A as

$$\begin{aligned} \bigcup A &= \{x \mid x \text{ belongs to some member of } A\} \\ &= \{x \mid (\exists b \in A)x \in b\} \end{aligned}$$

We need an improved union axiom to include cases where A were infinite, overcoming the limitation of defining unions strictly “one by one”.

Union axiom

For any set A , there exists a set B whose elements are exactly the members of the members of A :

$$\forall A \exists B \forall x [x \in B \leftrightarrow (\exists b \in A)x \in b]$$

For any A we can define $\bigcup A$ as

$$\bigcup A = \{x \mid (\exists b \in A)x \in b\}$$

See that for any two sets a and b we have

$$\begin{aligned} \bigcup \{a, b\} &= \{x \mid (\exists c \in \{a, b\})x \in c\} \\ &= \{x \mid x \in a \vee x \in b\} \\ &= a \cup b \end{aligned}$$

(one can check that the $\{x \mid x \in a \vee x \in b\}$ is the equivalent notation for the binary union.) This shows that our preliminary form of the union axiom can be discarded in favor of the new form—the set $a \cup b$ produced by the preliminary form can also be obtained from the pairing and revised form of the union axiom.

1.1.5 Redundance of the preliminary union axiom

Theorem 1.4. *Given the pairing axiom*

$$\forall u \forall v \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = u \text{ or } x = v)$$

and the union axiom

$$\forall A \exists B \forall x [x \in B \leftrightarrow (\exists b \in A) x \in b]$$

we can show

$$\forall a \forall b \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in a \text{ or } x \in b)$$

which is the preliminary union axiom determined earlier.

Proof. Let a and b be arbitrary sets. The pairing axiom asserts the existence of a set A where

$$\forall x (x \in A \leftrightarrow x = a \text{ or } x = b)$$

Now that we know set A exists, the union axiom asserts the existence of a set B where

$$\forall x [x \in B \leftrightarrow (\exists b \in A) x \in b]$$

Let x be arbitrary.

($\rightarrow$) First suppose $x \in B$. We can then declare some $y \in A$ such that $x \in y$. Since $y \in A$ we have $y = a \vee y = b$, and therefore $x \in a \vee x \in b$.

($\leftarrow$) Now suppose that $x \in a \vee x \in b$. In the case where $x \in a$, we know that $x \in a \in A$, so $x \in B$. The case where $x \in b$ is similarly proven. $\square$

1.1.6 Intersection

Theorem 1.5. *For any nonempty set A , there exists a unique set B such that for any x ,*

$$x \in B \leftrightarrow x \text{ belongs to every member of } A$$

Proof. We first prove existence. We want to show

$$\exists B(\forall x(x \in B \leftrightarrow \forall a \in A(x \in a)))$$

Since A is nonempty we can let c be some member of A . By the subset axiom we can assert

$$\exists B(x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in c \wedge \forall a \in A \setminus \{c\}(x \in a))$$

So we can declare some B such that the above is true. Let x be arbitrary.

($\rightarrow$) First suppose that $x \in B$, then let $a \in A$. We have two cases; first suppose $a = c$, then we know $x \in c = a$. Now suppose that $x \neq c$; then since $x \in A$ we have $x \in A \setminus \{c\}$ and therefore $x \in a$.

($\leftarrow$) Now suppose that $\forall a \in A(x \in a)$. Since $c \in A$, we must have $x \in c$. Let a be some element of $A \setminus \{c\}$; clearly $a \in A$, so $x \in a$. We have now shown $x \in c \wedge \forall a \in A \setminus \{c\}(x \in a)$, so $x \in B$. Existence is proven.

Uniqueness, as always, follows from extensionality. We consider some arbitrary B' and assume that $\forall x(x \in B' \leftrightarrow \forall a \in A(x \in a))$, then show that $B' = B$ using extensionality. $\square$

In contrast to the union operation, no special axiom is needed to justify the intersection operation. This theorem permits defining a unique intersection set for every nonempty set. We proved that for any nonempty A ,

$$\exists B(\forall x(x \in B \leftrightarrow \forall a \in A(x \in a)))$$

and that this set was unique for each A . Using the earlier notation we name this set

$$\bigcap A = \{x \mid x \text{ belongs to every member of } A\}$$

An edge case should be considered: our theorem proves existence of the intersection $\bigcap A$ for all nonempty A ; what happens in the case where $A = \emptyset$? In other words, is it the case that

$$\exists B(\forall x(x \in B \leftrightarrow \forall a \in \emptyset(x \in a)))$$

We can show that this implies (by vacuous truth)

$$\exists B(\forall x(x \in B))$$

which would contradict russells paradox.

1.2 Set algebra

The union operation for any two sets exists by the pairing, union, and extensionality axioms.

$$A \cup B = \{x \mid x \in A \vee x \in B\}$$

The intersection operation for any two sets exists by the subset and extensionality axioms.

$$A \cap B = \{x \mid x \in A \wedge x \in B\}$$

Also by the subset and extensionality axioms, we have the *relative complement* $A - B$ of B in A .

$$A - B = \{x \in A \mid x \notin B\}$$

also sometimes denoted as $A \setminus B$.

Note that we cannot form (as a set) the “absolute complement” of B , $\{x \mid x \neq B\}$. In this case the union with B , which must exist axiomatically, would be a set of all sets, which would contradict russell’s paradox.

The study of the operations of union ($\cup$), intersection ($\cap$), and relative complementation ($-$), together with the inclusion relation ($\subseteq$), is called the *algebra of sets*. The following identities, which hold for any sets, are some elementary facts of the algebra of sets:

Commutative laws

$$A \cup B = B \cup A \quad \text{and} \quad A \cap B = B \cap A$$

Associative laws

$$A \cup (B \cup C) = (A \cup B) \cup C$$

$$A \cap (B \cap C) = (A \cap B) \cap C$$

Proofs of these follow directly from the commutativity and associativity of the logical OR and AND.

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Distributive laws

$$A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$$

$$A \cup (B \cap C) = (A \cup B) \cap (A \cup C)$$

Proof. First we show $A \cap (B \cup C) = (A \cap B) \cup (A \cap C)$. Let x be arbitrary.
($\rightarrow$)

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